



the basic
idea

does free
will explain
any evil?

A large orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, containing the text "does free will explain all evil?" in white. The text is centered and arranged in three lines.

does free
will explain
all evil?

1. The 2004 Indian Ocean tsunami is an evil.
 2. There is no good which outweighs this event and which is such that an omnipotent being could not have brought about the good without the tsunami.
 3. A perfectly good being would eliminate every evil unless there was a good which outweighed that evil and it was impossible for that being to eliminate the evil without eliminating the good.
 4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1,2,3)
 5. If there is no omnipotent and perfectly good being, God does not exist.
-

C. God does not exist. (4,5)

The argument from natural evil

One line of response to this argument is to say that even though tsunamis are not caused by human free will, the evil they involve is.

Though earthquakes and the like are not caused by human free actions, our inability to avoid the harm caused by them is. In particular, the event of human beings removing themselves from the care of God - an event symbolized in the Judaeo-Christian tradition by the story of the Garden of Eden - placed human beings in a world in which they were subject to natural forces which they were then unable to avoid.

This capitalizes on the fact that natural disasters don't seem to be evil as such, but only evil insofar as they bring about suffering. Hence, if the suffering caused by natural disasters can be explained as the result of human free choice, we will have successfully explained all that needs explaining.

Here is one way of developing this thought:



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about the good without the strain.

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4. There is no omnipotent and perfectly good being. (1, 2, 3)



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God. It can explain that, it seems, if we make the following assumption:

Summing up so far: we have seen that Frege will promise to explain how

there could be evil in a world with a omnipotent and perfectly good

there are possible
situations which an
omnipotent
being cannot
bring about



we have
free will



free will is
a great good

the ability
to harm others
is a great good

**Free will
cannot
explain any
evil.**

Free will can explain some evil; but it can't explain all of the evil we find in the world.

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(1, 2, 3)

C. Good does not exist. (4,5)

5. If there is no dominant and perfectly good

being; God does not exist.



